

SC301 – Lecture 12: Marx, Ideology, and the Frankfurt School: Summary

Introduction

Marx, ideology and culture

- Marx was a polymath who was not only a writer and philosopher but also wrote fiction, poetry, and worked for radical newspapers as well as submitting articles to more popular magazines and newspapers. He was hence personally engaged in the production of wider culture, particularly reporting on worker's movements and other radical movements across Europe.
- Marx's work was not really about culture, but there are many references to ideology and the role of aspects of culture within it, what it means to be a worker in the cultural industries (for example, as an actor or as a musician) and whether cultural forms, compared to other forms of action, were a form of class consciousness.
- Marx was prolific. Often distinguish between the 'early' and 'late / mature' Marx (Grundrisse – outlines / Das Kapital). The early works of Marx focussed on ideology as an ideology imposed by the ruling class, and slightly later as reliant on the relationship between the economic base and superstructure. The later works of Marx on a Critique of Political Economy and concepts such as labour power, alienation, industry and commodification.

Marx - The German Ideology (1846)

Ruling class ideas and the 'means of mental production'

The ideas of the ruling class are in every epoch the ruling ideas, i.e. the class which is the ruling material force of society, is at the same time its ruling intellectual force. The class which has the means of production at its disposal, has control at the same time over the means of mental production, so that thereby, generally speaking, the ideas of those who lack the means of mental production are subject to it.

- Different ruling class in different epochs (Slavery – Kings and Pharaohs; Feudal – Kings and Lords; Capitalism – Capitalists). Current epoch – capitalism
- Rules in terms of materiality (economics) but also in terms of the sphere of ideas
- Means of mental production (schools, books, libraries, cultural forms), how working class mentality is produced
- Ideology is seen as arising from the ruling class as a form of ruling class similar to those in previous epochs – capitalism is different but still top-down ideology

Contemporary example of control of means of mental production

-Monopolisation of record companies, streaming services, ticket agencies and retailers. Cross-ownership of companies such as Amazon (retailer, online) that also owns streaming services. This enables the control of 'mental production' by capitalists.

How ideology inverts (from German ideology)

“If in all ideology men and their circumstances appear upside-down as in a camera obscura, this phenomenon arises just as much from their historical life-process as the inversion of objects on the retina does from their physical life-process”.

Ideology represents class relations in an illusory form in so far as these ideas do not accurately portray the nature and relative positions of the classes concerned; rather, ideology misrepresents these relations in a way which concurs with the interests of the dominant class.

-When we see something, our eyes invert the image and this is also how cameras work (camera obscura), it inverts the historical life processes of individuals. An example of this would be that ruling class individuals (such as Richard Branson, who set up Virgin records) is rich and successful because he is clever and talented whereas the material basis of this is the exploitation of labour – of artists and musicians who make the music that he sells – over their historical (entire) lives. This inversion concurs with the interests of the dominant class.

Marx – Contribution to a Critique of Political Economy (1859)

Base and Superstructure

-Looking at not just ruling class dominating the means of mental production, but also at what happens in the economic base. The superstructure (political-legal, originally, the state) arises from the economic base. Engels (in Anti-Dühring – response to a Dühring, a German social democrat, putting forward the argument for Marxism as a science) later extended this to include forms of culture, and the media, arise from this base. Engels and later economists such as Althusser introduced concepts of determination in the last instance (not immediate, only determined over a long period of history), relative autonomy (some independence from it) and overdetermination (lots of different economic and historical events leading to outcomes).

Marx – Capital: A Critique of Political Economy (Three volumes) (1867, 1885, 1894)

-Capital – three volumes (4 with theories of surplus value), finished by Engels after death

-Critique of political economy – not a new political economy (Marxist / Socialist) a critique of economics as a new science mystification etc

-Examines material conditions of production – critiques capitalism and idealism

Adorno and Horkheimer – Dialectic of Enlightenment (1947)

- Frankfurt school – Institute for Social Research University of Frankfurt (founded 1923) rise of Nazism, moved to Geneva (1933) and then New York (1935) – established critical theory, dominant ideology as ruling class ideology (cultural hegemony, hegemonic, total and unified ruling class ideas and the structure of ideas). Critical as opposed to traditional theory (not scientific method – facts are based on historical context of their formation and historical

context of the perceiver). Self-critical, no claim to universal truth, does not privilege materialism or idealism – methods from Marxism particularly the dialectic. Totalising philosophy also looking at mass psychology / psychoanalysis

- Dialectic – thesis (argument), anti-thesis (counterargument) – synthesis (new, more developed understanding) idealist
- Enlightenment dialectic is reason / science (thesis) against myth (antithesis) but has produced (synthesis) control / domination / rationalisation leading to new myth that hierarchies / control through science / technology.
- Total control of the population - Nazism / Stalinism / State capitalism / Culture Industry
Compares enlightenment to a dictatorship – man of science knows things so that he can control them
- Media impresses standardised behaviour / consumption on the individual as rational. Only freedom is freedom of the industrialists / monopolists.
- Essay – The Culture Industry: Enlightenment as Mass Deception ‘Culture today is infecting everything with sameness’, standardisation and mass production, details become interchangeable
- Culture no longer has to present itself as art, it is business.
- ‘Entertainment is the prolongation of work under late capitalism. It is sought by those who want to escape the mechanised labour process so they can experience it again’
- Something is provided for everyone, differences are hammered home and propagated
- The star system propagates the ideology that the ‘ordinary person’ can make it
- Enlightenment control / rationality lead to dictatorship / fascism as lack of thought ‘Enlightenment itself, having mastered itself and assumed its own power, could break through the limits of Enlightenment’ (something worse)

Benjamin - The Work of Art in the Age of Mechanical Reproduction (1935)

- Mass production / mechanical reproduction (in capitalism) reduces the ‘aura’ of art in that it is disconnected from where the art was made (locale) and its cultural and physical context. So this is disconnected from the reproduction.
- BUT it changes the ways in which art is consumed. High art is consumed for its cult status and its value in an exhibition (cult value and exhibition value). Mechanical reproduction voids those values but creates new values / ways of seeing. For example, through popular cinema people take the perspective of the camera. Through the consumption of music in clubs, people dance to music.

Now individuals can experience art in different ways, to think critically about the world and to consider a different life. Means of production of art democratised.